

Chapter 17: Embrace

"Ning Fuyi! Yiyi!" Several sharp screams came from overhead. It seemed Liu Wenzhu and Rong Jin wanted to chase after Ning Fuyi, but were pulled back to their original position by Elder Yuan Ming's two vine tendrils, who shouted angrily, "Do you not want your lives!"

The commotion overhead was soon replaced by the howling of wind. Ning Fuyi wanted to open her eyes to see the situation, but the powerful airflow continuously impacted her surroundings, blowing so that her vision was a complete blur. She could only summon her immortal power to barely protect her eyes.

This was definitely not the speed of an ordinary fall. Ning Fuyi knew in her heart that the ghost eye was like a giant suction cup, desperately trying to draw everything that approached it inside. Turbid qi¹ floated around, wrapping her like a whirlwind, almost stripping away all her strength. Ning Fuyi couldn't struggle free and could only curl up her body like a broken leaf caught in a whirlwind, desperately trying to minimize her injuries.

From time to time, fragments of stone scraped across her arms and face, leaving deep bloody marks like knife cuts. Ning Fuyi couldn't even open her mouth and could only close her eyes, cursing angrily in her heart while resigned to fate.

She had finally managed to live again - surely she wouldn't die so inexplicably in this ghost eye?

Fortunately, the falling process was brief. After dropping into the ravine that almost spanned the entire Copper River, the surrounding light suddenly dimmed, making it difficult for her eyes to adjust to such changes, and everything went black.

Ning Fuyi felt the airflow weakening and instinctively formed a hand gesture in front of her chest. Immortal power condensed into water droplets, wrapping around her vital areas. Though weak, it at least provided some cushioning.

The massive sound of water and ground collision rang out. At the same time, the falling sensation suddenly stopped. Ning Fuyi felt as if a boulder had struck her heart and lungs, her chest numbed from the shock. She groaned muffled and rolled out of the shattered water sphere, rolling several times in place before stopping.

For a full quarter-hour, Ning Fuyi remained in unbearable dizziness. She gritted her teeth and curled up in place for a long time before the scenery before her eyes slowly became clear.

She had reclaimed a life, Ning Fuyi thought painfully. Fortunately, she was now the thousand-year-old Ning Fuyi. If she were still the inexperienced young girl from her previous life, she would have died of fright halfway down.

It was also fortunate that the water-element heart techniques² that Chu Qingqiu had forced her to memorize came in handy. In that critical moment, she actually remembered them. Otherwise, even if she had nine lives, she would have perished here today.

The surroundings were very quiet, so quiet that only the whistling of wind remained. Ning Fuyi circulated her energy and lay down for a while longer. When the stuffy pain in her chest from the impact had eased somewhat, she slowly got up and cast a spell to dry the water stains on her body.

Her eyes had already adapted to the dimness here. The bottom of the valley wasn't completely without light, just much dimmer than the outside world.

The bottom of the valley was much as she had imagined. The ground was in complete disorder, piled with all kinds of bones and remains. Some had already dried and weathered, others were still fresh, emitting a nauseating stench of decay.

If one looked carefully, one could even see body parts belonging to humans.

Apart from these bones, there wasn't a trace of living creature's aura - not even a single blade of grass. There were only rocks of various sizes, covered with eerie fluorescence, as if inhabited by large swarms of fireflies, forming a stark contrast to the corpses strewn everywhere.

Ning Fuyi blinked and carefully stood steady. Looking up, this ravine was quite strange - the bottom was barren of any vegetation, while the mouth of the ravine was overgrown with layers of spider web-like vines that completely blocked out the sky.

Climbing up was impossible; she could only treat this as a desperate gamble and try flying. Ning Fuyi thought.

So she silently recited the heart techniques she had memorized. Water vapor appeared around her, slowly condensing into a solid water sword. However, just as she was about to step onto it to perform sword-flying techniques, the water sword seemed to be dispersed and exploded with a "bang," drenching Ning Fuyi with water droplets.

Ning Fuyi quickly pulled her sleeves up to cover her face, thinking this was bad. This ghost eye seemed to weaken the spells of cultivators. In that moment just now, she could clearly feel the loss of immortal power within her body.

What could she do now?

As they say, one wave had not yet settled when another arose. Just as she lost her composure, rustling sounds suddenly came from behind the rocks beside her, as if some living creature was crawling toward her. This movement was quite abrupt in the empty valley bottom. Even Ning Fuyi broke out in a cold sweat, gathering what little immortal power she had in her right hand while squinting toward where the sound came from.

Ning Fuyi's heart nearly jumped out of her throat. She held her breath, watching as the thing behind the rocks got closer and closer, until finally...

A small furry head popped out.

Wait! Ning Fuyi was stunned and immediately withdrew the immortal power she was about to release, staring in shock at the small white dog covered in dust, wagging its fluffy black and white tail.

"Ping'an?" Ning Fuyi was so surprised that her voice changed. She looked around, then limped over to the barking little dog and picked it up by the scruff of its neck.

Round black eyes, cotton candy-like fur covered in dust, and a tail wagging like a pinwheel - if it wasn't Ping'an, who else could it be?

"How are you here? Did you fall down with me?" Ning Fuyi suddenly had a splitting headache. She quickly examined it thoroughly and found no new injuries apart from being a dirty little dog again.

It seemed when she fell, Ping'an had followed her down.

But falling from such a height, how could Ping'an be completely unharmed...

As she pondered, the little dog suddenly barked twice and stretched its neck to lick Ning Fuyi's face, finally bringing back her attention.

No matter why, not being injured was a good thing. Right now, the most important thing was to find a way out. Ning Fuyi thought, and supported Ping'an's bottom. After it whined and settled steadily on her shoulder, she gritted her teeth and dragged her bruised leg, carefully walking forward through the bone-strewn ground.

Staying in place wasn't a solution. She was alone and helpless without immortal power. If night fell, there would be no possibility of getting out.

The bottom of the valley flickered with fluorescence, but it couldn't illuminate the path ahead. Ning Fuyi was constantly tripped by protruding bones or rocks, causing her to break out in cold sweat from the pain.

"Ning Fuyi, oh Ning Fuyi, look at what state the mighty Heaven-Slaying God-Demon has fallen to..." Ning Fuyi irritably wiped the dust from her face, muttering to herself while forcefully kicking away the skull of some poor soul in front of her.

At this moment, Ping'an on her shoulder suddenly whimpered. Just as Ning Fuyi was about to turn her head to look at it, she suddenly felt a murderous aura approaching. She nimbly spun around and watched as a bright red forked tongue flashed past her face, seeming to slow down in mid-air for a moment before swiftly retracting with a "swoosh."

This startled Ning Fuyi into a cold sweat.

She turned to look and saw a four-legged lizard pressed against the dark cliff beside her, its color similar to the cliff. Its body was covered in rock-like bumps. If it hadn't exposed its position just now, she definitely wouldn't have noticed it even if she had walked right against the cliff wall.

Fortunately, this four-legged lizard wasn't very large - not much longer than Ning Fuyi's height - and the murderous aura emanating from it was insufficient. It looked like just a low-level demon beast. Ning Fuyi breathed a slight sigh of relief, and her eyes gleamed as she came up with a plan.

After failing its first strike, the four-legged lizard's color suddenly changed. It no longer blended with the wall but returned to its original slimy flesh color. Its head turned, and its two small eyes fixed directly on Ning Fuyi, making her break out in goosebumps and grimace in disgust.

Quick as lightning, wind arose. The four-legged lizard suddenly leaped into the air, its tongue drawing a line invisible to the naked eye through the air, rushing toward Ning Fuyi's face.

The next instant, the tongue tip flew out like a sword and stuck to the rock with a muddy splat, dark green blood flowing from the severed end.

Ning Fuyi held a small knife that had just materialized in her hand, standing motionless with a smug grin at the four-legged lizard.

At that moment, the four-legged lizard's small eyes seemed to widen. Though it couldn't make expressions, Ning Fuyi could see its current heartbreak and rage. Sure enough, the four-legged lizard that had been clinging to the cliff suddenly moved its limbs, becoming a shadow racing toward Ning Fuyi, wanting to perish together with the one who had severed its tongue.

This was exactly what Ning Fuyi had been waiting for. She suddenly put away her smile, her eyes turning to their usual fierce coldness. Then she sent a small amount of immortal power toward the overhead, while her toes lightly touched the ground and her whole body moved backward.

With a thunderous crash, a rock several people wide fell from somewhere overhead, hitting the ground while splashing countless dust and flesh.

Ning Fuyi landed lightly, placing her finger at her nose tip. Just as she was about to step forward to check, her phoenix eyes suddenly lifted alertly. She held her breath and turned around, her heart seeming suspended in mid-air, skipping a beat.

Behind her, something had appeared at some point. The thing was almost unrecognizable, its entire body emitting rolling black qi, with only a pair of hollow eyes staring silently at Ning Fuyi through the black qi.

This scene was so terrifying that even Ning Fuyi almost cried out. She quickly frowned and retreated, trying not to disturb this massive creature.

However, she forgot that she wasn't the only living thing here. Before she could react, a sharp howl from the frightened Ping'an came from her shoulder. The cry immediately stimulated the demon creature, which suddenly leaped into the air, opened its bloody maw, and lunged to swallow Ning Fuyi.

If she could live another life, she would definitely poison Ping'an first, Ning Fuyi thought viciously as she faced the overwhelming stench.

This demon creature was extremely powerful. She could no longer muster any immortal power, and the creature's fangs were right before her eyes. She simply closed her eyes and held her breath, waiting for death.

The murderous aura burned the skin of her cheeks. In a flash, the pain suddenly stopped. A warm current surged from within her body, and white light feathers spread like gauze, blocking the murderous aura rushing toward her face.

Ning Fuyi opened her eyes in surprise. As the blinding white light pierced through her pupils, a sweet fragrance suddenly appeared behind her. Those arms pulled her, and she couldn't help but step back, turning around and closing her eyes as she fell into a warm embrace.

Those arms held her very tightly. For some reason, Ning Fuyi felt the unconcealed fear emanating from the other person.

Another beast's roar resounded in her ears, as if transmitted from the ninth heaven, inspiring inexplicable solemnity in one's heart. She heard a familiar cold voice from above her head.

"Bai Lin³, finish it."

¹ Turbid qi (浊气) - Impure or corrupted spiritual energy, often associated with evil or demonic forces.

² Heart techniques (心诀) - Internal cultivation methods focusing on controlling and directing spiritual energy through specific mental practices.

³ Bai Lin (白麟) - "White Qilin," referring to the white qilin (Chinese unicorn) that serves as Chu Qingqiu's spiritual beast companion.